



I WAS PROUD OF ZEENAT, BUT JEALOUS OF RAJ KAPOOR FOR MAKING ADVANCES ON WHAT I CONSIDERED MY SOLE POSSESSION, MY DISCOVERY, MY LEADING LADY, AND DESIRING HER WITH A KISS.



talked about glowingly, I loved it; and whenever and wherever I was discussed in the same vein, she was jubilant. In the subconscious, we had become emotionally attached to each other. After the premiere of *Ishq Ishq* at Metro cinema, Raj Kapoor kissed Zeenat in full view of the invited audience, congratulating her for her sparkling performance in the film. That must have made her evening all the more sparkling. Yet, I was jealous of him for making advances on what I considered my sole possession, my discovery, my leading lady, and desiring her with a kiss.

I felt I was desperately in love with Zeenat—and wanted to say so to her! To make an honest confession, at a very special, exclusive place meant for romance. I called her up to say, 'Zeenie, I want to go out on a date with you tonight.' 'But aren't we already going together to a party tonight?' she asked me. 'Let's just go there only for a brief while, say Hi to the gathering, and then quickly disappear!' Together we went to the party. It was on in full force. The first person who greeted Zeenat from a distance was a drunken Raj Kapoor, with a gallant drawl, 'There she is!' He threw his arms around her exuberantly. This suddenly struck me as a little too familiar. And the way she reciprocated his embrace seemed much more than just polite and courteous. My heart broke into pieces, I wanted to leave the party at once and go off somewhere alone, to be just by myself, so that I could swallow the humiliation thrust on my ego.

The girl with a designer suit and a felt hat on, with whom I had walked down the streets of Manhattan on her eighteenth birthday, kept coming to mind. I called Richa up from my sick

bed. She was all excitement when I told her that she stood a great possibility of being cast as an Indian girl who was born and brought up in America. 'But,' I added, 'I last met you almost two years ago. Send me your current photographs.' Within a week, a bunch of huge sexy blow-ups were lying on the table in my bedroom. Mona glared as I kept looking at them. Then she quickly picked them up, almost snatching them away from my hands, and kept them on a high table in a corner, away from my gaze and my grasp. A few days later, Richa Sharma was born to the world as the star of *Hum Naujawan*. As the

doing films?' I asked. She was camera friendly. On the way back from the studio, she was in my car—I had offered to drop her. She was wearing a large sexy pair of goggles that added to her appeal. 'I like your goggles,' I said. She took them off and put them into my pocket. 'Take them as a present from me.' 'But they suit you,' I said. 'That's why,' she shot back. I still have that pair of goggles sitting in some corner of my cupboard.

Zeenat and I started being linked with each other in the magazines and newspapers that people hungry for gossip love to read. Whenever and wherever she was